

BUDGIE • MELOPSITTACUS UNDULATUS

Keep your budgie the right way from day one.

A complete, fact-checked printable manual: cage setup, a pellet-forward diet and how to actually get there, household hazards, hormone and egg control, and the health pages that make the difference between a five-year budgie and a fifteen-year one.

INSIDE

- ✓ Cage sizing, and the bar-spacing figure that is a safety limit, not a preference
- ✓ Sexing by cere, a gram scale routine, and what a losing budgie looks like
- ✓ Four pellet conversion methods, three food charts, and the never-feed list
- ✓ Nine health pages, a symptom table, and fillable owner, vet and sitter sheets

40 pages

Beginner

Print or tablet

Version 2.1 • Sep 2026



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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't bought a bird yet

Read pages 4 through 12 in order before buying anything. Two decisions cost the most to undo: the cage on page 5, which people buy small and replace within a year, and whether you bring home one budgie or two on page 9, which decides how tame the bird becomes and how much of your day it needs. Settle both, then use the Budget and Shopping List on page 30 to buy once instead of twice.

If your budgie is already home

Start with the Setup Checklist on page 28 to audit what you have, then page 10 if the bird is on a seed mix. Diet is the single biggest lever on how long a budgie lives, and the conversion takes weeks, so starting it today matters more than reading the rest of this book first. If anything looks wrong, go straight to Health Red Flags on page 19.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 28: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 35: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 29: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 36: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 32: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 37: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 33: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 26: Reading Droppings & Hydration |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

A budgie is sold as the cheap, easy starter bird, and a lot of the care advice still in circulation was written to match that price rather than the animal. Seed-only feeding, a cage the bird cannot turn around in, and a kitchen window as a cage spot are all still normal advice somewhere. Every figure here is cross-checked against veterinary sources, listed on page 39, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

An avian veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is a professional call, not a page in this book. Budgies mask illness until they are genuinely sick, and they are small enough that the margin afterwards is hours, not days. Find a vet before you need one and write the number on page 29.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Melopsittacus undulatus</i> . Sold in the United States as a parakeet, in the UK and Australia as a budgerigar or budgie. Same bird
Adult size	About 7 in (18 cm) head to tail tip
Adult weight	25 to 35 g. Exhibition-bred birds run heavier and wider than pet-type budgies, so your bird's own baseline matters more than the range. See page 16
Captive lifespan	7 to 15 years. The low end is almost always diet: see page 20
Native range	The dry interior of Australia. Nomadic flocks that follow rainfall
Diet type	Grass-seed eater in the wild, kept on a pellet-forward diet in captivity. Page 10
Cage floor, one bird	18×18 in (46×46 cm) footprint as an absolute minimum. Length matters more than height
Cage target	20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm) or wider. Page 5 explains why two credible sources differ
Bar spacing	3/8 to 1/2 in (10 to 13 mm). A head-entrapment limit, not a preference
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C) is comfortable. Avoid drafts and sudden swings
Darkness needed	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted, every night. Page 7
Sexual maturity	6 to 12 months
Sexing	Cere color, reliable in adults and one of the few parrots where looking at the bird is enough. Page 16
Handling difficulty	Beginner. Built on trust with a flighted bird, never on restraint
Conservation status	Least Concern (IUCN)

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$175 to \$475 for equipment, plus \$45 to \$150 for the first avian vet exam. The bird itself is \$20 to \$80. Full breakdown on page 30.

Monthly ongoing

\$20 to \$45 for one bird, food and consumable toys included. Add roughly half again for a second budgie sharing the same cage.

THE LINE ITEM PEOPLE LEAVE OUT

Avian vets are a smaller and pricier specialty than general small-animal practice, and pet insurance is rarely available for a budgie. Diagnostics run \$50 to \$300 on top of the exam, and emergency care runs \$100 to \$1,500 or more. Most owners self-insure, which only works if the money is actually set aside. Page 30 treats it as a line, not an afterthought.

Cage size, bar spacing & placement

The purchase that is hardest to undo, and the one number that is a safety limit.

Two credible veterinary sources give different cage figures, and both are printed here rather than averaged. LafeberVet gives a minimum of 18 in (46 cm) wide and long and says cage length matters more than height. The MSD Veterinary Manual's cage table gives 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm) for a budgerigar. Treat 18×18 in as the floor below which a cage is not adequate, and 20×20×30 in or wider as what you should actually buy. Nobody has ever regretted the bigger cage.

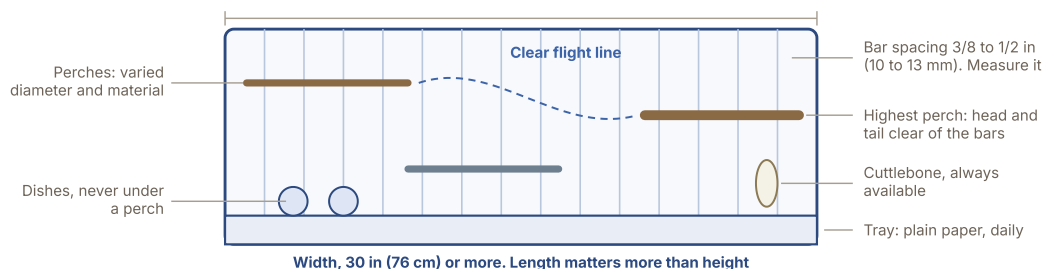
Shape matters as much as volume. A budgie flies in short lateral bursts rather than climbing, so a tall narrow cage sells you height the bird will not use. Given 30 in of width or 30 in of height at the same price, take the width every time.

BAR SPACING: 3/8 TO 1/2 IN (10 TO 13 MM)

LafeberVet gives approximately 3/8 in (0.95 cm); the MSD Veterinary Manual gives 0.5 in for a budgerigar. Anything wider is a head-entrapment risk, and a trapped budgie panics and injures its neck long before you find it. Measure the cage yourself rather than trusting the box. Avoid round cages, which give a bird no corner to settle in, and check the finish: galvanized bars and hardware are a zinc source, covered on page 8.

Where the cage goes

PLACE	WHY
Against a wall, at or near eye level	A cage in open floor space with movement on all sides reads as exposure to a prey animal. One solid side to back into settles a bird faster than anything else you can do in week one
A room the family actually uses	Budgies are flock animals and a bird kept in a spare room is alone whether or not it has a companion. Page 9
Not the kitchen, ever	Overheated nonstick cookware kills birds, and it is not a rare event. Page 8 gives the temperature and the mechanism
Out of direct all-day sun and off a draft	A caged bird cannot move out of the sun. Partial sun with shade available is fine; a sunny windowsill is not. Keep the cage off the floor and away from exterior doors and air-conditioning vents
Somewhere it can be made dark	Ten to twelve hours of uninterrupted darkness is a health requirement, not a nicety. A living room that stays lit until midnight needs a separate sleep cage. Page 7



BUY THE CAGE BEFORE THE BIRD

Set it up, fill it, and leave it running for a few days. It is far easier to discover that the door catch is flimsy or the tray does not slide out with nothing living in it, and a cage that arrives with the bird gets assembled in a hurry.

Perches, dishes & what to leave out

What goes in the cage, where, and the four things not to add.

Perches

A budgie spends essentially its whole life standing, so perch variety is a foot-health decision rather than a decorative one. Provide a mix of diameters and textures: natural wood branches of different thickness, at least one rope perch, and no more than one abrasive or cement perch positioned away from the favorite sleeping spot. A foot that has to adjust its grip through the day stays healthy; a foot gripping one uniform dowel at one diameter develops pressure sores and arthritis.

- Place the highest perch where the bird can sit upright without its head or tail touching the cage.
- Leave a clear flight line between two perches. A cage packed wall to wall with toys is a smaller cage.
- Skip sandpaper perch covers. They do not shorten nails usefully and they abrade the foot.
- Replace chewed wood perches rather than treating the chewing as a problem. Chewing is the point.

Dishes and water

Position food and water dishes so that nothing perches directly above them. Droppings in a water dish are a daily contamination problem, not an occasional one. Change water daily and wash dishes daily, and keep a spare set so a dirty one never stays in the cage while the other dries. Budgies do not need grit or gravel: some birds overconsume it and obstruct the gut, and a parrot husks a seed rather than swallowing it whole, so it has no use for it in the first place.

LEAVE THESE OUT

Nest boxes and happy huts. Any enclosed dark cavity is a nest site to a hen, and it is the single easiest way to start a chronic laying cycle. Page 17.

Mirrors. A budgie treats its reflection as a mate it can never resolve, and mirror-bonded birds regurgitate at the glass and become territorial about it.

Rope or fabric with loose fibers. Frayed strands wrap toes and cut off circulation. Trim rope perches and toys as they wear.

Anything with lead or zinc. Galvanized hardware, cheap bells, chain, and mirror backings. Page 8.

Cuttlebone and mineral block

Keep a cuttlebone or mineral block in the cage at all times. It gives the beak something appropriate to wear against, and it is a calcium source that matters most for a hen who may lay whether or not there is a male in the house. It is a supplement to a good diet, not a replacement for one: a bird eating mostly pellets is already getting its calcium, and a bird eating mostly seed is not going to be rescued by a cuttlebone alone.

LINE THE TRAY WITH PLAIN PAPER

Newspaper or plain paper towel, changed daily, is better than any loose substrate. It costs nothing, and it lets you read the droppings every morning, which is the cheapest health check a bird owner gets. Page 26 explains what to look for. Loose litter hides exactly that information and gets eaten.

Light, sleep & household climate

Day length is a health control, not a lighting preference.

A budgie reads day length the way it would in the Australian interior: long days mean the season to breed, short days mean it is not. A bird sitting in a living room lit until midnight is living through an endless summer, and the consequences show up as hormonal behavior, chronic egg laying in hens, aggression, and sleep debt that feeds feather plucking. This page and the egg pages are the same subject seen from two ends.

SETTING	TARGET
Darkness, every night	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted. Cover the cage or move the bird to a quiet sleep cage in an unused room
Daylight	A normal room's light on a consistent schedule. Indirect natural daylight is ideal; a bird does not need a special lamp to be healthy
Hormonal intervention	Cutting light to 8 hours a day is the standard first step in breaking a laying cycle, alongside removing nest sites; LafeberVet gives the same intervention as 8 to 10 hours. Merck names a photoperiod over 12 hours as a documented risk factor for excessive laying, which is the line a lit living room crosses. Page 17
Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C). A healthy budgie tolerates a wider range than that comfortably; it is the sudden change and the draft that cause problems, not the number
Humidity	Normal household humidity is fine. Very dry winter air suits a bird poorly, so bathing matters more in a heated house

What uninterrupted actually means

Covered but in a room where the television is on is not darkness, and a bird that wakes six times a night is sleep-deprived even if the total hours look right. Noise wakes a budgie as reliably as light does. If the cage lives in the main room of the house and the household stays up late, the honest fix is a second small cage somewhere quiet, used only for sleeping. It costs less than the main cage and solves a problem that no amount of covering solves.

Bathing

Offer a shallow dish of room-temperature water two or three times a week, or a light mist from a spray bottle aimed above the bird rather than at it. Some budgies bathe enthusiastically and some never do; both are normal. Bathing keeps feather condition good, helps in dry heated air, and takes the edge off a molt. Never use soap or any additive, and let the bird dry in a draft-free room rather than with a hair dryer, which is itself a nonstick-coated appliance in some models. Page 8.

SLEEP DEBT LOOKS LIKE A BEHAVIOR PROBLEM

A budgie that is irritable, bites more than it used to, screams in the evening, or has started plucking is worth investigating from the sleep side before anything else. It is the cheapest thing on the list to fix and it is wrong in a large share of households, because nobody thinks of a light switch as husbandry.

Household hazards & bird-proofing

The most important page in this book. A bird's lungs make ordinary household air lethal.

A bird's respiratory system moves air through the lungs in one direction and extracts oxygen on both the inhale and the exhale. It is far more efficient than a mammal's, and that efficiency is exactly why airborne poisons that a person would merely find unpleasant kill a budgie in the same room. Nothing else in this book has as short a distance between a normal household act and a dead bird.

PTFE: NONSTICK COOKWARE

Overheated nonstick surfaces release a gas at around 280°C (536°F), which is well within reach of an empty pan left on a burner. In a small bird, acute death is often the only sign there was ever a problem. Keep birds out of the kitchen entirely, never run a self-cleaning oven with a bird in the house, and check the other sources Merck names: irons and ironing board covers, some self-cleaning ovens, heating elements in some reverse-cycle heat pumps, and some heat lamps.

Airborne

- **Aerosols of any kind.** Hairspray, deodorant, air freshener, oven cleaner, spray sunscreen, cleaning sprays.
- **Scented candles, incense, plug-in air fresheners, and burned or melted plastic.** All named in the veterinary literature as irritant or toxic to birds.
- **Cigarette and cannabis smoke, and fireplace or wood-stove smoke.** Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in any room with gas heat or a gas range: CO is odorless to you, and the bird has no margin.
- **Fresh paint, varnish, and new carpet.** Move the bird out of the house, not into another room, and ventilate for days rather than hours.

Heavy metals

A budgie chews everything it can reach, which turns ordinary hardware into a poisoning route. Lead sources named in the veterinary literature include window blinds, costume jewelry, mirror backings, some bird toys, hardware cloth and curtain weights, and lead tastes sweet, which is why a bird that finds it keeps chewing. Zinc sources include galvanized toys, chains, mesh, bells, keys and pennies minted after 1982; electroplated galvanized metal is considered safe, but hot-dipped, the cheaper and commoner coating, leaches zinc without the bird swallowing a visible flake. Signs of either are non-specific and easy to miss: appetite loss, weight loss, regurgitation, diarrhea, weakness, and increased drinking and urination. Buy cage hardware and toys that state stainless steel or powder-coated, and treat an unlabeled shiny metal bell as a maybe rather than a yes.

Physical hazards during out-of-cage time

- Ceiling fans off, always, before the door opens.
- Windows and mirrors covered or curtained. A budgie flies into glass at full speed.
- Open water: toilet lid down, sinks empty, pots covered, mugs finished.
- Hot surfaces: stove, kettle, candles, a just-used iron.
- Other pets shut out of the room, with no exceptions for the friendly ones.
- Toxic houseplants moved out. If you cannot identify a plant, it goes.
- Doors and windows shut, and everyone in the house told the bird is out.
- Sticky traps, mouse bait and insect sprays removed from the room entirely.

A CAT OR DOG BITE IS A SAME-DAY EMERGENCY WITH NO VISIBLE WOUND

Cat saliva carries *Pasteurella*, which at a bird's body temperature can multiply fast enough to cause fatal sepsis within hours, and the puncture is usually invisible under feathers. Any contact at all between a cat's mouth and a bird is a vet visit today, not a wait-and-see. The same goes for a dog's grab, where the crushing injury is internal.

One budgie or two, and the talking trade-off

The decision that shapes every other one, and the honest version of the trade.

Budgies are flock birds. In the wild they move across the Australian interior in flocks that can number in the thousands, and none of that instinct switches off in a cage. A budgie alone is not automatically miserable, but the company has to come from somewhere, and there are only two places it can come from: another budgie, or you, several hours a day, every day, for the bird's whole life. Deciding which honestly, before you buy, is worth more than any other page here.

	ONE BUDGIE	A PAIR
What it needs from you	Several hours of genuine daily interaction, split across sessions, indefinitely	Daily interaction still, but the bird is not alone when you leave the house
Tameness	Usually tamer and faster to tame, because you are the flock	Slower and often less complete. Two birds bond to each other first
Talking	Far more likely, and mostly in males. A single male bonded to one person is the setup that produces a talking budgie	Unlikely. Birds that have each other to talk to have no reason to learn your words
Noise	Quieter, though never silent	Chattier all day, which most owners come to like
Cost	Baseline	Roughly half again on food and toys, plus a wider cage
Risk it adds	Loneliness if the daily time does not happen, which shows up as plucking and screaming	A male and female pair will breed given any nest site, and a hen that starts laying is a real health problem. Page 17

THE HONEST RECOMMENDATION

If you work away from home, or you want a bird because it looks low effort, get two. If you are home most of the day and want a tame bird that might talk, one is genuinely the better outcome for both of you, provided the time is real. Two hens or two cocks avoids the breeding question entirely; a mixed pair with no nest box and a controlled photoperiod is manageable, but it is a thing you have to actively manage rather than a thing that takes care of itself.

Adding a second budgie later

Budgies are also the one small parrot commonly kept in groups rather than in ones and twos. A colony is a different problem from a pair, not a bigger one. No verified space-per-bird or sex-ratio figure exists in a source worth printing, so what actually works is more feeding stations than birds, perches and sightlines that stop one bird controlling the space, and the understanding that any mixed-sex group with a nest site available is a breeding setup whether or not you meant one.

This works, and it is the commonest reason a settled single bird suddenly has company. Two things make or break it. Quarantine the new bird for 30 to 45 days in a separate room first, which is not optional and is covered on page 27. Then introduce in separate cages side by side for a week or more before any shared space, and make the first shared space neutral rather than the resident bird's cage. A resident budgie defends its cage; the same two birds meeting on a play stand often get along immediately.

What a lonely budgie looks like

Feather plucking, pacing the same stretch of perch over and over, screaming beyond normal contact calls, and obsessive attachment to a mirror or a toy. All four are also signs of other problems, so treat them as a prompt to check both the social side and the health side rather than a diagnosis. Page 24 covers the differential.

Diet: pellets, seed & converting a seed eater

The single biggest lever on how long your budgie lives.

Wild budgies eat grass seed, which is true and is the reason most pet budgies are fed badly. Wild seed is eaten green and milky, in enormous variety, by a bird flying miles a day for it. A bowl of dry sunflower and millet in a cage is a different food eaten by a different animal. An all-seed diet is deficient in protein, vitamins and minerals including calcium and vitamin A, and the conditions that follow from it, obesity, fatty liver disease, and the tumors on page 20, are the reason a budgie dies at five instead of twelve.

COMPONENT	SHARE OF DIET	NOTES
Formulated pellets	60 TO 80%	The base. Buy a pellet sized for a budgie or small parrot; a large-parrot pellet is unusable. A bird taking 75 to 80% of its diet as pellets does not need vitamin supplements
Vegetables, greens and fruit	20 TO 25%	At most, and weighted toward vegetables rather than fruit. Pages 11 and 12
Seed	THE REMAINDER	A very small part, and never the whole diet. Best used inside a foraging toy rather than an open dish, so it costs the bird effort
Millet spray	ONCE OR TWICE A MONTH	Small quantities. It is the most effective taming treat you have, which is exactly why it gets overfed
Honey sticks, seed bells, yogurt drops	NOT RECOMMENDED	Sugar and fat in a form that displaces real food
Grit or gravel	NOT NEEDED	Some budgies overconsume it and obstruct the gut. A cuttlebone covers the mineral question
Fresh water	ALWAYS	Changed daily, dish washed daily

Four ways to convert a seed eater, from a veterinary source

1. **Offer pellets first thing in the morning**, before anything else goes in, when the bird is hungriest.
2. **Spread pellets on a flat surface** such as a shallow tray or a sheet of paper, which mimics ground feeding and reads as food rather than as an object.
3. **Grind pellets to powder and coat a moist food with it**, then increase the particle size over days until the bird is taking whole pellets.
4. **Mix pellets into the seed**, then decrease the seed and increase the pellets a little each day.

Expect it to take days, weeks or months. That is the published range, not a failure on your part.

NEVER STARVE A BIRD ONTO PELLETS

A budgie weighs about 30 g and has no meaningful energy reserve. Pulling the seed and waiting is how birds die during a diet change. Weigh the bird on a gram scale through the conversion (page 16), keep offering the old food until the new food is genuinely being eaten, and check the droppings daily: fewer and smaller droppings mean less food is going in, whatever the dish looks like. Lafeber's limit for a bird this size is firm: never let a budgerigar go more than **12 hours** without eating, and stop and call an avian vet at a **10% drop** from its starting weight.

Safe vegetables, greens & herbs

The 20 to 25% that pellets do not cover, weighted toward vegetables rather than fruit.

Bright yellow, red and orange vegetables carry the most vitamin A, and vitamin A deficiency is one of the commonest nutritional problems in seed-fed birds. It shows up as sneezing, nasal discharge, swelling around the eyes, poor feather quality and feather picking, so a chart that looks like a garnish list is doing real work. Chop small enough for a 30 g bird to manage, offer fresh in the morning, and take it out after a few hours in a warm room before it spoils.

TIER	FOODS
DAILY	Bell pepper of any color (including the seeds), broccoli florets and stalk, carrot and carrot tops, sweet potato cooked and cooled, winter squash, kale, dandelion greens, spinach, romaine and other dark leaf lettuces, cilantro, parsley, basil
TWO OR THREE TIMES A WEEK	Peas, green beans, corn kernels, zucchini, cucumber with skin, beet greens, chard, bok choy, cooked plain quinoa or brown rice, sprouted seed
SMALL AMOUNTS, OCCASIONALLY	Celery and iceberg or head lettuce. Both are mostly water with little nutrition, so they displace better food rather than adding anything. Birds like the crunch, which is the only argument for them
NEVER	Avocado, onion, garlic. See page 12 for the full never list

WASH EVERYTHING, AND PREFER ORGANIC WHERE YOU CAN

Birds are very sensitive to pesticides, chemicals and sprays, and a budgie eats a large amount relative to its body weight. Wash produce thoroughly under running water even when it is labeled pre-washed, and treat anything from a garden that has been sprayed as off the list entirely.

Getting a suspicious bird to try vegetables

Most budgies refuse new food the first several times it appears, and most owners stop before the bird starts. Persistence over days and weeks is what works, not variety on any single day. Three things that help:

- **Offer it clipped to the bars at perch height**, not in a dish on the floor of the cage. Food a budgie has to work at is food it takes seriously.
- **Eat it in front of the bird.** Budgies are flock feeders and copying what the flock eats is how a young bird learns what food is.
- **Chop it into pellet-sized pieces** and mix a little into the pellet dish. Familiar shape, new content.

Sprouting

Sprouted seed is the closest a home kitchen gets to what a wild budgie actually eats, and the sprouting process shifts a dry seed's balance away from fat. Rinse thoroughly twice a day, sprout for one to two days only, refrigerate, and throw away anything that smells sour or looks slimy. Spoiled sprouts grow bacteria and fungus fast, and a bird this size has no margin for a gut infection, so if you are not going to be careful about it, skip sprouting and stay with fresh vegetables.

A CHOP, MADE ONCE A WEEK

Dice a mix of the daily-tier vegetables, portion it into an ice cube tray, and freeze. Thaw one cube each morning. It removes the daily preparation excuse, which is the real reason fresh food stops appearing in most households after the first month.

Fruit, treats & the never-feed list

The smallest part of the diet, and the part where the real dangers are.

Fruit is sugar with vitamins attached. It belongs inside the 20 to 25% fresh share rather than on top of it, and the orange-fleshed fruits earn their place better than the sweet pale ones because of the vitamin A. A budgie is small enough that a grape is a meal, so portion by the piece, not by the handful.

TIER	FOODS
BEST CHOICES	Mango, papaya, cantaloupe. All three are high in vitamin A and are the fruits worth offering most often
FINE, IN SMALL PIECES	Apple with the seeds removed, pear, berries, banana, melon, kiwi, orange and other citrus in small amounts, grapes cut in half
TREATS, NOT FOOD	Millet spray in small quantities once or twice a month. A little plain cooked pasta or unsweetened whole-grain cereal. Nothing sweetened, salted or fried
NEVER	Avocado, onion, garlic, chocolate, caffeine, alcohol, anything very salty, and processed food cooked with butter or oil

THE NEVER LIST, AND WHY

Avocado carries persin in every part of the plant, and smaller birds are the more sensitive. Respiratory distress typically appears about 12 hours after ingestion, with death possible inside one to two days. No part of it, including guacamole on a fingertip.

Onion and garlic contain chemicals that may damage a bird's red blood cells.

Chocolate, caffeine and alcohol are never fed to a bird in any amount.

Salt. A budgie's kidneys are handling a fraction of a person's food volume. A single salted chip is a large dose.

Apple seeds and stone-fruit pits come out before the fruit goes in. Remove cherry pits specifically.

Anything moldy. Fruit left in a warm cage grows mold within hours, and a budgie will eat it.

Fresh food and the clock

Fresh food goes in when you get up and comes out a few hours later, sooner in a warm room. Leaving a wet vegetable in the cage all day is how a good diet turns into a bacterial problem, and it also removes the one useful signal you get from a food dish: whether the food was eaten or ignored.

What about the bird that only wants millet

Almost every budgie prefers millet to everything else on offer, in the way a child prefers dessert, and the veterinary guidance to hold it to small quantities once or twice a month is exactly because the preference is so strong. Use it deliberately: a millet head is the most effective taming currency you have (page 14) and it is wasted as a dish filler. Break a spray into short pieces and hand-feed those rather than clipping a whole one into the cage.

A BIRD EATING MOSTLY PELLETS DOES NOT NEED VITAMIN DROPS

Once 75 to 80% of the diet is pellets, supplemental vitamins are not needed, and water-soluble vitamin additives foul the water and encourage bacterial growth in the dish. A bird still on seed is the one with the deficiency, and the answer there is the conversion on page 10, not a bottle.

Common mistakes & enrichment

The ten things that go wrong most, and the one behavior that fixes several of them.

THE MISTAKE	WHAT TO DO INSTEAD
Seed dish topped up daily and never emptied	Husks sit on top and look like food. Blow or tip the husks off before deciding the dish is full. Convert to pellets, page 10
A cage bought on price, then replaced within a year	Buy width once. Page 5
A happy hut or nest box added for comfort	Take it out. It is a nest site and it starts laying cycles. Page 17
A mirror as company	Take it out and add a second budgie or more of your own time. Page 9
Cage in the kitchen or near the stove	Move it today. Page 8
Lights on until midnight	Cover the cage or use a sleep cage. Page 7
Wings clipped at point of sale, by default	It is a decision, not a service. Page 15
Never weighed	A gram scale is the cheapest diagnostic you will ever buy. Page 16
Nails and beak trimmed on a schedule	Neither should need routine trimming on good perches and a good diet. An overgrown beak is a symptom, page 23
Waiting to see if it improves	A fluffed budgie sitting on the cage floor has been ill for a while already. Page 19

Foraging first

A wild budgie spends most of its active day looking for food. A cage with an open dish removes that entire behavior and gives nothing back, which is where cage boredom, pacing and plucking start. Enrichment that restores foraging does more than any single toy purchase, and it costs nothing: wrap part of the daily ration in a twist of plain paper, put some in a shallow tray under a layer of shredded paper, thread a few pellets into a cardboard tube, or hide small portions in three places instead of one. Change the method every few days so it stays a puzzle rather than a memorized route.

The rest of the enrichment picture

Destructible, and cheap

Plain paper, cardboard, soft untreated wood, palm leaf, yucca. Budgies destroy these fast, which is the point. A rotating supply of cheap shreddables beats one expensive toy that survives a year.

Rotation, not accumulation

Keep three to five toys in the cage and swap two of them weekly. A toy ignored for a week becomes interesting again after a fortnight away. A cage crammed with twenty permanent toys is visually busy and behaviorally empty.

FLIGHT IS ENRICHMENT

Supervised out-of-cage flight in a bird-proofed room does more for a budgie's physical condition than every toy on this page combined, and it is the single best obesity intervention available to an owner. Page 8 is the checklist that makes the room safe, and page 15 covers what clipping takes away.

Handling, taming & the bite problem

Trust with an animal that can leave. There is no restraint-based version of this.

Where the bird came from sets the starting line. A hand-raised budgie may step up on day one; a parent-raised or aviary-raised bird has never been handled and needs weeks. Neither is better as a pet, but pushing a nervous bird at a hand-raised bird's pace sets you back rather than forward.

Settle first, for a week or two

Do nothing but feed, change water and clean for the first week or more. Sit near the cage and talk. Position the cage at or near eye level and against a wall: movement above or behind a caged bird triggers a genuine predator response, and a bird spending its energy on that has none left for you.

The progression

1. **Hand in the cage, doing nothing.** Rest your hand inside, not reaching, until the bird stops reacting to it. This step is longer than people expect and it is the one that actually works, because it hands the bird control of the timing.
2. **Millet from your fingers.** Hold a short piece still and close enough that the bird has to come to it. Do not follow the bird with it.
3. **Step up.** Once food is being taken calmly, press a finger gently against the lower chest just above the feet and give a consistent cue word. The pressure tips the bird's balance backward onto your finger; you are not lifting it.
4. **Out of the cage.** Only in a bird-proofed room, page 8, and only once step-up is reliable inside.

Short and frequent beats long and forced. Five minutes three times a day is worth more than an hour on Sunday.

NO DOMINANCE, NO PUNISHMENT, NO GRABBING

Advice about establishing dominance over a bird is outdated and actively counterproductive. Budgies are prey animals: a hand that reaches in and grabs is a predator strike, and it costs weeks of trust in seconds. Never punish a bite. Punishment teaches a prey animal that hands are dangerous, which is the opposite of the thing you are trying to build.

Biting, and what it actually means

A budgie bite is almost always one of four things: fear, cage territoriality, hormones, or the bird using its beak as a third foot to test whether a perch is stable. The last is not a bite at all and is the commonest thing new owners misread. Hens tend to be more territorial and bite harder than cocks, particularly in breeding condition, which is normal for the species.

- **Cage aggression:** take the bird out to a neutral perch first, and do not reach in to retrieve it.
- **Hormonal biting:** page 17. Light, nest sites and petting down the back are the drivers.
- **Fear biting:** you moved too fast. Go back a step.

Stress signals, and the towel

Frantic flapping, panting or open-mouth breathing, and repeatedly fleeing from your hand all mean stop and try later. If you genuinely have to restrain a budgie for medication or to check an injury, use a small towel rather than bare hands, so the bird associates the unpleasant part with the towel instead of with you. Restrain around the shoulders, never around the chest: a bird's breathing depends on the chest wall moving, and a firm grip suffocates it.

Wing clipping & flight

You will be asked about this in week one, usually by whoever would do the trim.

Clipping means shortening some of the primary flight feathers so a bird cannot gain height. It is not permanent: the cut feathers are dead tissue and the bird regains flight at its next molt. There is no fixed interval to quote, because Merck notes molt timing varies with nutrition, daylight and humidity, so check the wings rather than the calendar. It is also not a training tool. A clipped budgie is not tamer, quieter or better behaved; it is a budgie that cannot get away from anything, which is a different thing from a budgie that has chosen not to.

The case for clipping

- A household with doors opening onto a street, or people who will not reliably check before opening one.
- Large windows and mirrors that cannot be covered.
- A bird that panics and repeatedly flies into things during the settling-in period.
- A brief clip while a specific, temporary risk is fixed.

The case against

- Flight is the main exercise a caged budgie gets, and obesity is this species' biggest killer. Page 20.
- A clipped bird still gets startled and still leaves the perch, but lands hard. Keel and leg injuries follow.
- Falling repeatedly makes some birds more fearful, not calmer.
- A bird that escapes while clipped cannot climb, cannot gain height, and cannot return.

IF YOU DO CLIP, THESE ARE THE RULES

Only primary flight feathers are trimmed, and Merck's method is four to seven of the outermost primaries on both wings, cut below the coverts that overlay them, with the secondaries closer to the body left alone because those are what let a bird slow down and land. The number depends on the individual bird's weight and flying ability: a heavier bird needs fewer feathers cut, a lighter one more. Trimming only one wing is not recommended, because it leaves the bird unable to steer and it crashes. Have it done by an avian veterinarian or an experienced technician the first time, and watch, rather than learning on your own bird. A cut into a blood feather, one still growing and still supplied with blood, bleeds heavily and needs pressure and a same-day vet.

What a correct clip leaves the bird able to do

Glide gently to the floor from perch height without dropping like a stone, and keep its balance. If the bird plummets, too much was taken. If it can climb and circle the room, nothing useful was achieved. The window between those is narrow, which is one honest argument for leaving a budgie flighted and fixing the room instead.

The recommendation this book makes

Default to flighted, and make the room safe (page 8) rather than the bird incapable. Clip only for a specific, named risk that you cannot otherwise remove, and revisit the decision at each molt rather than treating it as a standing arrangement. A budgie that flies confidently around a safe room is fitter, lands better and is easier to keep at a healthy weight than one that cannot.

LEG BANDS AND MICROCHIPS

Most budgies come with a closed leg band carrying the breeder's code and year. Leave it on unless a vet advises otherwise; it is the only identification the bird has, and it is what gets a lost budgie home. Check under it during the weekly handling check for swelling or a caught fiber, which is the one real risk a band carries.

Sexing by cere, weight & body condition

One of the few parrots you can sex by looking, and the vital sign that is a number.

The cere

The cere is the fleshy patch above the beak where the nostrils sit, and in adult budgies it is colored by sex. Cocks show a blue to purple-blue cere. Hens show tan, brown or pale white, thickening and roughening in breeding condition. Juveniles of both sexes show pink or pale purple that has not settled yet, which is why sexing a very young bird by cere alone does not work; it resolves somewhere between 6 and 12 months, the same window as sexual maturity. Some color mutations, notably the recessive pied and lutino and albino birds, keep a pinkish cere into adulthood and are the genuine exceptions.

A BROWN CRUSTY CERE MEANS DIFFERENT THINGS IN THE TWO SEXES

In a hen it is usually breeding condition, and it smooths and lightens again when she comes out of it. In a cock the same texture change is not hormonal and is worth a vet visit: scaly face mites give a crusty porous surface (page 23), and a cere changing color in a mature male is also associated with reproductive tumors. Sudden change, bleeding, or a change alongside lethargy or labored breathing is a vet appointment whatever the sex.

Weight is this species' vital sign

You cannot see a budgie's condition through its feathers, and a bird hides illness until it cannot. Weight is the one number that moves before anything is visible, and a digital kitchen scale reading in single grams costs less than a bag of pellets. Train the bird to step onto a perch fixed to the scale, or use a small tub.

WHAT	TARGET
Typical adult weight	25 to 35 g. Exhibition-bred birds run heavier. Your bird's own settled baseline is what matters
How often	Daily, same time each day, before the first feed. Lafeber's Susan Orosz is specific: a gram scale, used daily, with the number written down, because it is the chart rather than any single reading that shows a trend. Log it on page 36
Act on	A drop of more than about 10% off the bird's own baseline, or any steady downward trend over three weighings
Obesity	Roughly 20% over ideal weight, or a body condition score of 4 out of 5 on the keel
During a diet change	Daily, not weekly. Page 10

Feeling the keel

The keel is the ridge of breastbone running down the center of the chest. Rest a fingertip either side of it with the bird held gently in a towel or sitting on your hand. On a bird in good condition the muscle rises to just below the ridge on both sides, so the keel is a shallow edge you can feel but not see. A sharp prominent keel with hollows either side means the bird is thin. A keel you have to press to find, with the muscle bulging above it and a rounded feel to the lower belly, means overweight. Do this at the weekly weighing so the number and the feel travel together.

WRITE THE BASELINE DOWN BEFORE YOU NEED IT

A vet asking what the bird normally weighs is not making conversation. The difference between a bird at 34 g today and a bird that was 38 g a month ago is a diagnosis; a bird with no history is a guess. Three weighings in the first month establish a baseline that pays off for the next decade.

Hens, hormones & chronic egg laying

A single hen with no male in the house can lay, and repeatedly laying is what harms her.

Budgerigars are one of the three species named most often in the veterinary literature for chronic egg laying, alongside cockatiels and lovebirds. A hen lays because her body has read the environment as a breeding season, and a male is not required for that. Each clutch draws calcium out of her, and a hen who lays clutch after clutch runs into calcium depletion, egg binding, and prolapse. One clutch in a lifetime is a normal event; a hen laying every few weeks is a medical problem that needs the environment changed, not the eggs removed.

REFERENCE FIGURE

Sexual maturity	6 to 12 months
Typical clutch	4 to 6 eggs, laid roughly every other day
Incubation	About 18 days from the start of sitting

The triggers, in the order worth removing them

1. **Any dark enclosed cavity.** Nest box, happy hut, a tent, a covered food dish, a cardboard box on the floor, the gap behind the sofa during out-of-cage time. This is the strongest and easiest trigger to remove.
2. **Long day length.** Reducing daylight to 8 hours a day is the standard intervention, and it is the lever this whole page turns on. Page 7.
3. **A mate.** That includes a mirror, a favorite toy the bird regurgitates to, and in some birds a person. Remove the object; separate a paired bird if the laying continues.
4. **Petting down the back and under the tail.** Restrict affection to the head and neck, which is where a budgie preens a flock-mate rather than a mate.
5. **Abundant rich food and constant access to it.** Rising food availability is a breeding signal. Conversion to a formulated pelleted diet is part of the standard management.

DO NOT TAKE THE EGGS AWAY

Pulling a clutch tells the hen the nest failed, and she lays a replacement clutch, which is exactly the cycle you are trying to stop. Leave the eggs, or swap them for dummy eggs, and let her sit out the roughly 18 day incubation until she loses interest. That is the budgerigar's own figure from LafeberVet, not the 21 to 28 days quoted as a general parrot range: use the species number, because it is the bird's biology that decides when she gives up on a clutch. Removing the environment's breeding cues is the intervention; removing the eggs is the mistake.

When the environment is not enough

A hen who keeps laying after the nest sites are gone, the light is at 8 hours, the mate object is removed and the diet has changed is a veterinary case, not a husbandry one. Hormonal treatment exists and works: leuprolide acetate is given by injection at 800 mcg/kg every three weeks for three doses and then as needed, and a deslorelin implant placed under the skin or into muscle is the longer-acting option. Both need an avian vet, and neither substitutes for fixing the environment, because the cues will simply restart the cycle when the drug wears off.

CALCIUM, BEFORE IT BECOMES AN EMERGENCY

A laying hen is spending calcium she may not have. Keep a cuttlebone or mineral block available at all times, and get the diet onto pellets, which carry a workable calcium to phosphorus ratio where a seed mix does not. A calcium-deficient hen lays thin-shelled eggs, and thin-shelled eggs are what get stuck. That is page 18.

Egg binding

A hen who cannot pass an egg has hours, not days. This is the page to know by heart.

Egg binding is a failure to pass a formed egg, and in a bird this small it kills quickly. The egg presses on the kidneys and the major vessels, and it obstructs the single opening the bird uses for both droppings and eggs, so a bound hen stops passing droppings as well. Calcium deficiency and obesity are the two commonest predisposing factors, which is why the diet pages and this one are connected.

SIGNS, ROUGHLY IN THE ORDER THEY APPEAR

Straining, tail bobbing or pumping with each effort, and a wide-legged stance. Then a hen sitting on the floor of the cage rather than perching, depressed, with her eyes closed. Then labored breathing. A swelling low in the abdomen may be visible or palpable. Sometimes an egg is visible at the vent, or tissue prolapses from it. Late on, one or both legs go weak, because the egg presses on the nerves running to them. Fewer droppings, then none, is the sign that decides it. VCA adds a marker worth holding to on its own: no egg passed in 48 hours by a hen you know is laying. Any hen on the cage floor and fluffed is an emergency whether or not you knew she was laying.

What to do, in order

1. **Call the avian vet now.** Before anything else. Say the words "possible egg binding" so the practice treats it as an emergency slot rather than an appointment.
2. **Warmth and humidity while you travel.** Move her to a small carrier lined with paper towel, keep the ambient temperature up at around 80 to 85°F (27 to 29°C), which sits inside the 80 to 90°F (27 to 32°C) range LafeberVet gives for a bird under supplemental heat where VCA puts a recovering bird's ideal at 75 to 80°F (22 to 25°C), and add humidity if you can. Back off if she shows flat sleek feathers, wings held out from the body, or open-mouth breathing, which mean she is too hot. Warmth alone resolves some mild cases and buys time in all of them.
3. **Do not stop offering food and water.** A 30 g bird has no reserve. Leave both within reach in the carrier.
4. **Keep her quiet and dark in transit,** and do not keep checking on her.

THINGS PEOPLE TRY THAT MAKE IT WORSE

Never massage or squeeze the abdomen. A broken egg inside the bird turns a treatable obstruction into peritonitis and sharp fragments.

Never try to pull the egg out or insert anything into the vent.

Do not put oil into the vent. It is a folk remedy that soaks the feathers, chills the bird and achieves nothing.

Do not wait overnight to see if she passes it. Overnight is the whole window.

What the vet will actually do

Fluids, injectable calcium, pain relief, and a warm humid environment resolve a large share of cases without anything invasive; the calcium restores the contractions that were failing. If that does not work, the egg can be collapsed and removed under anesthesia, and in a hen with a badly adhered egg or repeated episodes the surgical option is removal of the reproductive tract, which also permanently ends the laying problem. Ask about that last option directly if this is not the first episode.

Preventing the next one

Every prevention step is on page 17, and the two that matter most are calcium and day length. A hen who has been bound once is likelier to be bound again, so treat the first episode as the signal to change the environment properly rather than as bad luck. If she is on seed, the conversion on page 10 is not optional after an episode of binding.

Health red flags & what to tell the vet

A budgie hides illness until it cannot. By the time it looks sick, it has been sick a while.

Prey animals conceal weakness because looking ill in a flock makes you the one the hawk picks. That instinct does not switch off in a cage, so a budgie that finally looks unwell is usually well into the problem rather than at the start of it. This page exists to move the moment you notice it earlier.

SAME DAY, NO WAITING

Sitting on the floor of the cage instead of perching.

Fluffed up and sleeping during the day, particularly on both feet rather than one. The foot is the tell: a resting budgie tucks one up, a cold or ill one plants both.

Tail bobbing with every breath, or open-mouth breathing, or any audible click, wheeze or change of voice. A **fanned** tail, spread flat and then settling, is only excitement and is a different thing.

Not eating, or droppings that have stopped or shrunk sharply.

Bleeding from anywhere, including a broken blood feather.

A hen straining with a wide stance. Page 18.

Any contact with a cat or dog's mouth, even with no visible wound. Page 8.

Sudden collapse or seizure, especially if anything was cooking or spraying in the house.

Within a few days

- Weight down more than about 10% off the bird's own baseline, or three weighings trending down.
- A change in droppings lasting more than 24 hours: color, consistency, number or volume. Page 26.
- Sneezing, a wet or stained cere, or swelling around the eyes.
- New lumps anywhere, particularly on the chest or belly.
- Lameness, a foot that will not grip, or a bird favoring one side. This is not always an injury. Page 20.
- Feather loss that is not symmetrical, or feathers that come away with sheaths still on. Pages 22 and 25.
- A crusty cere or beak, especially in a cock. Page 23.
- Any change in an established behavior: a bird that always chatters going quiet, or a tame bird suddenly refusing to come out.

Normal values worth knowing

MEASURE	NORMAL
Body temperature	About 107°F (41.8°C). Far higher than a mammal, and not something you measure at home
Heart rate	Around 274 beats per minute
Respiratory rate	60 to 75 breaths per minute at rest, with no visible tail movement
Weight	25 to 35 g, and stable against the bird's own baseline. Page 16

WHAT TO HAVE READY WHEN YOU CALL

The bird's current weight and its usual weight. How long the sign has been present. What it eats, in percentages rather than brand names. Whether anything was cooking, cleaning, spraying or burning in the house. Whether it has been out of the cage, and where. Whether any other bird in the house is affected. Take a photograph of the cage tray from this morning; droppings are diagnostic and they do not travel well. Write the vet's number and an after-hours number on page 29 today, not on the day you need them.

Obesity, fatty liver & tumors

The condition group that shortens more budgie lives than everything else on the site combined.

Obesity and hepatic lipidosis

Obesity in a bird is defined as roughly 20% over ideal weight, or a body condition score of 4 out of 5 on the keel. An obese budgie is at increased risk of fatty liver disease, in which fat accumulates in the liver and displaces working tissue, and also of atherosclerosis and heart disease. The cause is almost always the same: a calorie-dense seed diet in a cage that offers no flight. It is the single biggest preventable problem in pet budgies, and it is preventable by two things that are free, converting to pellets (page 10) and letting the bird fly (page 13).

SIGN	WHAT YOU NOTICE
Early	Nothing visible. Weight creeping up on the scale is the only sign, which is the argument for the scale
Established	A rounded lower belly, the keel hard to feel, breathlessness after short flight, reluctance to fly at all
Liver involvement	An overgrown, soft or flaking beak, overgrown nails, poor feather color, green staining in the urates, and lethargy
Advanced	Labored breathing, abdominal swelling, and in some birds sudden death with no preceding illness

WEIGHT LOSS IS DONE SLOWLY, AND WITH A VET

Crash-dieting a 30 g bird mobilizes fat into a liver that is already struggling, which makes it worse rather than better. Convert the diet, measure portions, add flight, and take the weight off over months while weighing weekly. A bird already showing an overgrown beak or green urates needs a veterinary work-up before any diet change, not after.

Lipomas and xanthomas

Lipomas are benign fatty growths, most often on the chest or belly, and xanthomas are yellow thickened areas of skin loaded with cholesterol, both associated with high-fat seed-heavy diets. A budgie with one is telling you about its diet. They are not usually urgent, but a growing lipoma interferes with flight and can ulcerate, and any new lump is worth a vet appointment rather than a decision made at home about what kind of lump it is.

Tumors, and the sign nobody expects

Budgerigars have an unusually high rate of tumors for a pet bird, and kidney tumors in particular are noted as common in this species. The presenting sign is often not a lump at all: a tumor sitting against the nerves that run past the kidney causes lameness or paralysis in one leg or both, because the nerve supply to the leg is compressed. A budgie that starts limping, drags a foot, or cannot grip a perch on one side is a vet visit, and it is a mistake to assume the bird knocked itself during a flight.

THE CERE IS A TUMOR SIGN IN COCKS

Reproductive tumors change the hormone balance, and in a mature male budgie one of the visible results is a cere shifting from blue toward brown. A hen's cere turning brown is ordinary breeding condition; a cock's is not, and it earns an appointment. Page 16 covers the normal version so you can tell them apart.

Respiratory disease & psittacosis

Fast-moving, and one of them is catching for people in the house.

Any breathing sign in a budgie is urgent. The respiratory system that makes a bird so efficient also leaves very little reserve, and birds that are visibly struggling to breathe have often been compensating for days. Tail bobbing with each breath, open-mouth breathing, a click or wheeze, a change in the voice, and a tail that pumps at rest are all the same message.

The common causes, in rough order

CAUSE	WHAT POINTS TO IT
Bacterial or fungal infection	Often secondary to poor air quality, chronic stress, or a diet-driven vitamin A deficiency. Sneezing, a wet or crusted cere, and nasal staining above the beak
Vitamin A deficiency	Seed-fed bird. Sneezing, nasal discharge, swelling around the eyes, conjunctivitis, poor feather quality. Reverses with diet, but the infection on top of it still needs treating. Page 10
Goiter	A stridor, wheeze or click with no discharge, caused by an enlarged thyroid pressing on the airway. Page 23
Inhaled toxin	Sudden onset, often in more than one bird at once, often with nothing else wrong beforehand. Page 8
Psittacosis	Below
Non-respiratory causes	An abdominal mass, egg binding, or obesity can all present as breathlessness. Page 20

Psittacosis, or parrot fever

Caused by the bacterium *Chlamydia psittaci*, and especially common in cockatiels, budgerigars and small parrots. In the bird the signs are non-specific: lethargy, nasal and eye discharge, weight loss, diarrhea, and characteristically lime-green or yellow-green droppings, because the organism attacks the liver. It is treatable. The treatment is doxycycline, given orally or by injection. Forty-five days has been the standard course, but the public-health compendium makes a budgerigar-specific exception: **30 days is effective in this species**, and recent work puts 21 to 30 days within reach for psittacines generally, with a retest two to four weeks after the course ends. The length is still the point: a short course does not clear it and the bird relapses. Every bird in the house is treated, not just the sick one.

THIS ONE INFECTS PEOPLE

Psittacosis spreads to humans by inhaling dried droppings and respiratory secretions, so cleaning a cage is the exposure. In people the incubation is 5 to 14 days and the illness starts abruptly with fever, chills, headache, aching muscles and a dry cough, and it can progress to pneumonia. Fewer than 1% of properly treated patients die, but it is frequently misdiagnosed because nobody mentions the bird. **Tell your own doctor you keep a bird.** When cleaning a cage during a suspected case, dampen the surfaces first so nothing goes airborne, wear gloves and an N95 respirator, and never dry-sweep or vacuum dried droppings.

What you can do before you get there

Keep the bird warm and quiet, around 80 to 85°F (27 to 29°C), inside LafeberVet's 80 to 90°F range for a bird under supplemental heat where VCA puts a recovering bird at 75 to 80°F. Flat sleek feathers, wings held out, or open-mouth breathing mean too hot. Leave food and water within reach at perch height so it does not have to move to reach them, and stop any spraying, cooking or cleaning in the house. If a toxin is suspected, get the bird into fresh air first and call from outside. Do not give any human medicine, and do not use over-the-counter bird antibiotics sold without a prescription; they are the wrong drug at the wrong dose and they delay the visit that would have worked.

Polyomavirus, French moult & PBFD

Two viruses that both cause feather damage, and telling them apart matters.

Avian polyomavirus

This virus is so closely tied to this species that its other name is budgerigar fledgling disease. It hits young birds hardest. In unweaned chicks the presentation is an acute one: sudden lethargy, the crop stops emptying, and death follows within 24 to 48 hours, with signs appearing 7 to 10 days after exposure. VCA puts mortality at up to 100% in birds under 15 days old, and notes that many juvenile and newly weaned parrots die quickly with no clinical signs at all. Budgerigars that survive past about three weeks of age typically do not die of it but develop the feather form instead, which is where the old aviary name comes from. Budgerigars also have one transmission route no other affected species has: vertical transmission from an infected parent straight into the egg, which is why a clean-looking breeding pair is not proof of anything.

FRENCH MOULT

The feather form of polyomavirus. Flight and tail feathers are dystrophic: they fail to grow properly, break, or drop out, leaving a fledgling that cannot fly. Aviculturists have called these birds runners or, where the down persists without proper flight feathers, feather dusters. Many affected birds go on to live normal lives as non-flying pets, but the bird is a virus source for other birds in the house. A vaccine exists: manufacturers recommend the first dose once a chick is over 35 days old, with a booster 2 to 3 weeks later. That is a breeder's decision more than a pet owner's, and it is a fair question to ask the breeder you buy from.

Psittacine beak and feather disease

PBFD is caused by a circovirus and is the other feather-destroying virus people worry about. The species it is reported in most are African grey parrots, eclectus parrots, lovebirds, lorikeets and historically cockatoos, so it is a much less likely explanation for a scruffy budgie than polyomavirus is. When it occurs, the picture is abnormal feathers that are pinched or clubbed at the base and shed easily with slow or absent regrowth, beak lesions, and immune suppression that lets other infections in. Diagnosis is a PCR test on feces, feather dander or blood, and the test detects infected birds that look completely healthy, which is exactly why it belongs in a quarantine panel. Page 27.

The four-way differential on a bird losing feathers

CAUSE	PATTERN	REGROWTH
Normal molt	Symmetrical, left matching right, new pin feathers pushing up as old ones drop. No bald skin	Normal. Page 25
Plucking	Only where the beak reaches. Head and face untouched, chest and legs bare. Broken shafts left behind	Normal if the behavior stops. Page 24
Polyomavirus	Young bird, flight and tail feathers, often unable to fly at fledging	Poor or absent
PBFD	Progressive over molts, feathers pinched or clubbed at the base, beak involved, head feathers affected too	Slow, abnormal, worsening

The line that separates the first two from the last two is the head. A budgie cannot reach its own head with its beak, so a bird with bare or abnormal head feathers is not plucking itself, and that finding moves the case from a behavioral problem to a veterinary one immediately. A second bird plucking the first is the exception, and it is why the pairing question on page 9 matters here too.

Scaly face mites, megabacteriosis & goiter

Three conditions this species gets more than most, and all three are treatable.

Scaly face and leg mites

Caused by the mite *Knemidocoptes pilae*, and one of the few budgie problems visible from across the room. It produces white, porous, proliferative crusts at the corners of the mouth, on the cere and beak, and sometimes around the eyes, on the legs or at the vent. The honeycombed texture is characteristic. Left alone it deforms the beak permanently, so it is worth catching early, and it is contagious to other birds in the house.

TREATMENT

Ivermectin at 0.2 mg/kg by mouth or by injection, or moxidectin at 0.2 mg/kg by mouth or applied to the skin, repeated after two weeks. This is a prescription from an avian vet at a dose calculated for a 30 g bird, not a pet-shop mite spray and not a dog product measured by eye. Clean and replace wooden perches and porous cage furniture while treating, and have any other birds in the house checked.

Megabacteriosis, or avian gastric yeast

Despite the old name, the organism, *Macrorhabdus ornithogaster*, is a yeast rather than a bacterium, and it is one of the small pet birds it most often affects, alongside cockatiels, lovebirds, parrotlets and finches. Budgerigars carry the longest history with it, though at least one peer-reviewed case series found it more often in the cockatiels it examined than in the budgies. It lives in the proventriculus and interferes with digestion. The classic picture is the "going light" bird: a budgie eating normally or even ravenously while steadily losing weight, sometimes regurgitating, sometimes passing whole undigested seed in the droppings. Mortality across affected birds runs anywhere from 10 to 80% depending on the bird and the strain, which is why the weekly weighing on page 16 earns its place: this disease is a falling number long before it is anything you can see.

- **Diagnosis** is by finding the organism in a fresh dropping under the microscope, or by a PCR test on droppings. It sheds intermittently, so one clear sample does not rule it out.
- **Treatment** with the best published success rate is amphotericin B at 100 mg/kg by mouth twice daily for 30 days. Shorter courses fail. Voriconazole at 10 mg/kg twice daily has been reported anecdotally.
- **During and after treatment** expect at least one repeat fecal exam while the course runs and another once it ends, because a bird can look and act recovered while still shedding the organism.
- **The uncommon acute form** is worth knowing: budgerigars in otherwise good condition have been documented collapsing and dying within 12 to 24 hours, usually from bleeding into the proventriculus. Any of the signs above plus sudden weakness is a same-day visit, not a wait-and-see.

Goiter, from iodine deficiency

A seed diet is iodine-poor, and without iodine the thyroid enlarges. The gland sits at the base of the neck, right next to the airway, so the sign is respiratory rather than a visible swelling: a stridor, a wheeze or a repeated click when the bird breathes, sometimes with regurgitation as the enlarged gland presses on the crop and esophagus. It is much less common now that pellets are normal, and it remains one of the clearest arguments for them. Treatment is Lugol's iodine, one drop per 250 mL of drinking water, until the bird is converted onto a pelleted or properly fortified diet, which then fixes the underlying cause.

OVERGROWN BEAK AND NAILS ARE A SYMPTOM, NOT A GROOMING TASK

A healthy budgie on good perches and a cuttlebone maintains its own beak. A beak that keeps overgrowing points at liver disease (page 20), at scaly face mites, or at a past injury to the growth plate. Trimming it addresses the shape and not the cause, so a bird needing repeated trims needs a work-up. Never trim a beak yourself: it carries a blood supply and nerves.

Feather plucking & behavioral health

Rule out the medical causes first. Most owners work this list backwards.

Feather destructive behavior is a symptom with a long list of causes, and the mistake that costs the most time is treating it as a boredom problem from the start. Budgies pluck less often than the larger parrots do, so a plucking budgie deserves a proper look rather than another toy. Work the list in this order.

CHECK	WHAT IT LOOKS LIKE, AND WHAT TO DO
1. Is it plucking at all?	Head feathers intact and only reachable areas bare means plucking. Symmetrical loss with pin feathers coming up means molt (page 25). Abnormal head feathers means a virus (page 22)
2. Medical	Skin disease, mites, an internal problem causing pain over one spot, liver disease, and vitamin A deficiency all cause plucking. A vet visit with a skin and dropping work-up is step two, not step ten
3. Sleep	Fewer than 10 to 12 hours of uninterrupted darkness is a common and easily missed driver. Page 7
4. Hormones	Chronic hormonal stimulation drives plucking around the vent and legs particularly. Page 17
5. Air quality	Cigarette smoke, aerosols, scented products and very dry heated air all irritate skin. Page 8
6. Foraging and company	Only now. Restore foraging, increase out-of-cage flight, and address the loneliness question honestly. Pages 13 and 9

WHAT THE ENRICHMENT RESEARCH ACTUALLY SUPPORTS

Work on captive parrots links consistent environmental enrichment to less feather-destructive behavior compared with birds kept without it, and foraging opportunities specifically stand out as one of the higher-impact changes available. That is a real finding and it is why page 13 leads with foraging rather than with toys. It is not, on its own, a treatment for a bird that is plucking because it is ill.

Other behavior worth reading

- **Beak grinding, on one foot, eyes half closed.** Contentment, almost always just before sleep, and it worries every new owner exactly once.
- **Eye pinning**, the pupils flashing wide and narrow. High arousal rather than happiness: it comes with aggression as readily as with play, so read the rest of the bird before putting a hand near the beak.
- **Pacing the same stretch of perch** repeatedly. Usually a cage that is too small or too empty, sometimes frustration at something visible outside it.
- **Screaming beyond contact calls.** Budgies chatter constantly and that is normal. Persistent screaming is usually a learned behavior that gets rewarded by someone returning to the room, and it is unlearned by returning before it starts rather than after.
- **Regurgitating onto a mirror, a toy or a person.** Affection, in budgie terms, and a hormonal signal. Remove the object. Page 17.
- **Head bobbing and beak tapping in a cock.** Courtship display, entirely normal, and a signal that the bird is in breeding condition.
- **Sudden fear of a person the bird liked.** Something changed: glasses, a hat, a hair color, a nail color. Budgies are strongly visual and it usually resolves in days.

NEVER USE A BITTER SPRAY OR A COLLAR AS A FIRST MOVE

Both treat the behavior while the cause continues, and a collar on a bird this small interferes with feeding and balance. They have a place, prescribed by a vet, for a bird injuring its own skin. They are not a starting point.

Molt & seasonal behavior

Normal, uncomfortable, and misread as illness roughly every time it happens.

A budgie replaces its feathers gradually rather than all at once, and a molting bird looks worse and behaves worse than a healthy bird should. Knowing what a normal molt looks like saves an unnecessary vet visit, and more usefully it stops an abnormal one from being dismissed.

NORMAL MOLT	NOT A MOLT
Symmetrical. Feathers lost from the left match the right	Bare patches only on one side, or only where the beak reaches
Pin feathers pushing up before the old ones drop, so no bald skin shows	Bald skin visible, or feathers that never regrow
Pins are gray-blue shafts with a waxy sheath the bird flakes off by preening	Feathers pinched or clubbed at the base. Page 22
The bird is quieter, sleeps more, and is touchier about being handled	The bird is fluffed, on the cage floor, or off its food. Page 19
Head pins are itchy and a paired bird will preen them for its partner	Head feathers missing in a single bird. That is not self-inflicted

Helping through a molt

- **Bathe more often.** Water softens the sheaths and makes preening them off easier. Page 7.
- **Feed properly.** Feathers are protein, and a molt is the most expensive thing a budgie's body does. It is the worst moment to be on a seed diet.
- **Expect it more than once a year.** Merck's picture is a full molt at least annually, with many birds also running a smaller partial molt about six months after the main one.
- **Handle less, and expect grumpiness.** Pin feathers on the head are genuinely tender, and a bird that bites during a molt is not regressing.
- **Never pull a pin feather.** They carry a blood supply while growing.
- **Keep the room warm and draft-free.** A part-feathered bird loses heat faster.

A BROKEN BLOOD FEATHER BLEEDS SERIOUSLY

A growing feather has a blood supply, and a snapped one can bleed enough to matter in a bird this size. Apply **firm, steady pressure** with clean gauze, and put styptic powder or cornstarch on the exposed broken tip of the shaft, **never down into an open follicle**, which can damage the follicle permanently. If it has not stopped within two to three minutes, call an avian vet. Do not pull the feather: VCA's current guidance is that pulling one at home is not recommended, because it leaves the shaft open and can cost more blood than it saves, and even in a clinic it is a last resort.

Seasonal behavior

Budgies breed opportunistically rather than to a fixed calendar, which is why an indoor bird under household lighting can come into condition at any time of year and often does. Expect chattier, more territorial, more restless behavior when a bird is in condition, and in hens a browner, thicker cere. It is normal biology. It only becomes a problem when the environment keeps a hen in that state, which is the entire subject of page 17. If seasonal behavior in your house is really year-round behavior, look at the light before anything else.

Reading droppings & hydration

The cheapest daily health check you have, and the reason the cage tray gets plain paper.

A bird dropping is three things at once, and separating them is what makes the check useful. The **fecal** part is the solid green or brown coil. The **urates** are the chalky white portion, uric acid, which is how a bird excretes nitrogen while conserving water. The **urine** is the clear liquid. Each of the three changes independently and each means something different, which is why "the droppings look wrong" is not a useful thing to tell a vet and "the urates have turned green" is.

COMPONENT	NORMAL	WORTH ACTING ON
Feces	Firm, coiled, green to brown. Color follows the food, so pellets with dye give reddish or orange feces and blueberries give purple for a few hours	Mushy or semi-liquid fecal material is true diarrhea and needs a vet. Black or tarry suggests bleeding higher up. Bulky and pale, or undigested seed passing through whole, suggests the gut is not absorbing. Page 23
Urates	Chalky white	Green or yellow urates point at the liver, and lime-green is the classic psittacosis picture. Page 21. Red or brown discoloration can mean blood, which raises lead among other things. Page 8
Urine	A small clear halo	A large watery halo with the fecal part still formed is polyuria, not diarrhea. It can be a normal response to stress or to a lot of watery fruit, and it can be kidney disease or infection. VCA notes polyuria is often the first sign of kidney damage from zinc, page 8
Number and size	Steady, day to day, on the same diet	Fewer or smaller droppings means less food is going in, whatever the dish looks like. In a hen, none at all with straining is an emergency. Page 18

POLYURIA AND DIARRHEA ARE NOT THE SAME THING

Owners report both as "wet droppings" and the difference decides how worried to be. Look at the solid part. If the fecal coil is still formed and there is simply a lot of clear liquid around it, that is polyuria. If the fecal material itself is mushy or liquid, that is diarrhea, and diarrhea in a budgie is a same-week vet visit at the latest. Any abnormality that persists beyond 24 hours is worth a call.

How to actually do the check

Plain paper on the tray, changed every morning. Glance at it while you change it: number, size, and the three colors. That is the whole routine and it takes five seconds. Loose litter and grit paper both make it impossible, which is the real reason page 6 rules them out. When something looks wrong, photograph the paper before you throw it away. A photograph travels to the vet; a description does not.

Hydration

A healthy budgie passes a dropping roughly every 20 to 30 minutes, and one noticeably larger dropping first thing in the morning is normal rather than a problem: it is the night's worth held over. Whole undigested seed passing through is different, and Merck lists it as a sign of avian gastric yeast, where a bird keeps eating and still loses weight, so it means weigh the bird and call the vet rather than change the food. Page 23.

Budgies come from an arid environment and are efficient with water, so dehydration is not obvious. The signs are a bird that is quiet and fluffed, a tacky rather than moist mouth if a vet checks it, and skin over the eyelid or the toes that is slow to spring back when gently tented. Sunken eyes are late. Wet vegetables contribute real water, which is one more argument for the fresh share of the diet, and a bird that has stopped eating has usually stopped drinking too. Never try to syringe water into a budgie's mouth at home; a bird this small aspirates easily and it kills.

Quarantine & adding a second bird

Thirty days of inconvenience against a disease that can take the whole household.

Every bird that enters your home is quarantined, with no exceptions for a bird that looks perfectly healthy, came from a good breeder, or is only visiting. Looking healthy is the specific thing this species is good at, and the two diseases that spread fastest between pet birds, psittacosis and polyomavirus, both have carriers with no signs at all. The public health guidance is to isolate newly acquired birds, including birds that have been to shows, exhibitions and fairs, for at least 30 days, and to **test** them before adding them to a group. Routine prophylactic antibiotic treatment is explicitly discouraged in that same guidance, because it can harm the bird and breed resistant strains: quarantine and a test, not a course of doxycycline just in case. Merck's figure for adding a bird to an aviary or an established multi-bird house is 90 days with testing, since an infected adult can shed polyomavirus intermittently for up to 90 days.

RULE	WHY
30 to 45 days	Take 30 as the floor and 45 if you already keep birds. Longer is better and shorter is not quarantine
A separate room, door closed	Ideally on separate air. The main routes here are airborne dust and dried droppings, so the same room with a sheet between the cages achieves nothing
Separate everything	Dishes, perches, toys, cleaning cloths, and the tray liner. Nothing crosses between the two rooms and goes back
Established birds first, the new bird last	Feed, water and clean for the resident birds before going anywhere near the new one, every single day. Then wash your hands and change your shirt
A vet visit during quarantine	The point of the 30 days is to use them. A well-bird exam plus a PCR panel covering psittacosis, polyomavirus and PBFD is the version that actually protects the household
Weigh every few days	A new bird losing weight in quarantine is the earliest signal you will get. Page 16

THE SINGLE-BIRD HOUSEHOLD IS NOT EXEMPT

If this is your first bird, quarantine still applies, because psittacosis infects people (page 21). A new bird's first month is when it is likeliest to be shedding, and it is the month when a new owner handles it most and cleans the cage least confidently. Wash hands after handling, dampen the tray before you lift the paper, and do not kiss a bird on the beak, however much it invites it.

After quarantine: the introduction

- Cages side by side, a few feet apart, for a week or more.** The birds will call to each other, which is the whole point. Watch for interest rather than alarm.
- Cages closer, then adjacent.** Beak contact through bars is fine. Toes through bars is where a fight does damage, so keep an inch of gap.
- Neutral ground first.** A play stand or a table, never inside the resident bird's cage. A budgie defends its cage and will meet the same bird peaceably on a perch it does not own.
- Shared cage last, and supervised.** Two food dishes, two water dishes and two of every favorite perch. Most resource fights are about there being one of something.

Chasing, beak fencing and a bit of shouting are negotiation. Grabbing a foot, pinning a bird down, or one bird unable to reach food are fights, and they mean separate the birds and go back a step. If the pairing is a cock and a hen, read page 17 before they share a cage, not after.

Setup checklist & targets

Print this one. Audit an existing setup against it, or buy against it.

Housing

- ☐ Cage at least 18×18 in (46×46 cm) in footprint; 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm) or wider is the target
- ☐ Bar spacing measured at 3/8 to 1/2 in (10 to 13 mm)
- ☐ Rectangular, not round; stainless or powder-coated, not galvanized
- ☐ Against a wall, at or near eye level, in a room the family uses
- ☐ Not in or adjoining the kitchen. No exceptions
- ☐ Out of all-day direct sun and off any draft
- ☐ Cover or sleep cage available for 10 to 12 hours of darkness
- ☐ Tray lined with plain paper, changed daily

Inside the cage

- ☐ Perches of varied diameter and texture, natural wood among them
- ☐ No perch directly above a food or water dish
- ☐ A clear flight line between two perches
- ☐ Cuttlebone or mineral block, always available
- ☐ Three to five toys, at least two of them destructible
- ☐ A foraging feeder or paper wrap in daily use
- ☐ No nest box, happy hut, tent or enclosed cavity
- ☐ No mirror
- ☐ No frayed rope or loose fiber anywhere
- ☐ No grit or gravel

Diet and equipment

- ☐ Budgie-sized formulated pellets, 60 to 80% of the diet
- ☐ Fresh vegetables offered daily, 20 to 25% with fruit
- ☐ Seed limited; millet only in small quantities, once or twice a month
- ☐ Two sets of dishes, washed daily, water changed daily
- ☐ Digital gram scale, reading in single grams
- ☐ Travel carrier, ready before you need it
- ☐ Avian vet identified, number written on page 29
- ☐ Nonstick cookware audited, aerosols moved out of the bird's air

Targets at a glance

Room temperature	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C), no drafts, no sudden swings
Darkness	10 to 12 hours, uninterrupted, every night
Weight	25 to 35 g, stable against the bird's own baseline, weighed weekly
Out-of-cage flight	Daily, supervised, in a bird-proofed room
Vet	A well-bird exam on arrival, then a wellness check every 6 to 12 months

Emergency & quick targets card

Fill this in today. Cut it out or photograph it and keep it on your phone.

Avian vet _____	
Phone _____	Hours _____
After-hours / emergency clinic _____	
Phone _____	Drive time _____
Backup carer _____	Phone _____
Bird's name _____	Hatch or purchase date _____
Leg band number _____	Baseline weight (g) _____

Go now, do not wait

- On the cage floor, fluffed, or sleeping in the day
- Tail bobbing with each breath, or open-mouth breathing
- Bleeding from anywhere, including a broken blood feather
- Not eating, or droppings stopped
- A hen straining, wide-legged. Page 18
- Any contact with a cat or dog's mouth
- Collapse, seizure, or a suspected fume exposure
- Sudden lameness or a foot that will not grip

WHILE YOU TRAVEL

Small carrier lined with paper towel, low perch or none at all, food and water within reach at floor level. Warm, around 80 to 85°F (27 to 29°C), inside LafeberVet's 80 to 90°F range for a bird under supplemental heat, and dark and quiet. Flat sleek feathers, wings held out, or open-mouth breathing mean too hot. No draft from a car vent. Take a photograph of this morning's cage tray. Bring the bird's weight, its usual weight, and the pellet or seed bag.

Targets, restated

Cage floor, minimum	18×18 in (46×46 cm). Target 20×20×30 in (51×51×76 cm) or wider
Bar spacing	3/8 to 1/2 in (10 to 13 mm)
Room temp / darkness	70 to 80°F (21 to 27°C); 10 to 12 hours dark, cut to 8 to break a laying cycle
Diet	60 to 80% pellets, 20 to 25% vegetables and fruit, seed the remainder
Weight	25 to 35 g. Act on a 10% drop from baseline
Quarantine, new bird	30 to 45 days, separate room
PTFE danger point	280°C (536°F). An empty pan reaches it in minutes

Last wellness exam _____ Next due _____

IF A BUDGIE ESCAPES

Most stay close for the first day and go quiet with fear rather than calling. Put the cage outside with food and a second bird visible, play budgie chatter, and search at dawn. Post locally the same hour and call vets and shelters: a found budgie is usually handed in rather than caught.

Budget & shopping list

Itemized, and the lines add up to the totals. Prices are US retail, September 2026.

One-time setup

ITEM	LOW	CONSIDERED
Flight cage, 30 in (76 cm) or wider, correct bar spacing	\$80	\$250
Perches, varied diameter and material	\$15	\$25
Food and water dishes, two sets	\$10	\$20
Toys: foraging feeder plus destructible starter set	\$20	\$40
Cuttlebone and mineral block	\$5	\$12
Digital gram scale	\$12	\$25
Travel carrier	\$20	\$45
Cage cover, or a small sleep cage	\$10	\$35
First bag of budgie-sized pellets	\$12	\$25
Equipment subtotal	\$184	\$477
The bird	\$20	\$80
First avian vet exam, within the first two weeks	\$45	\$150
Total to get started	\$249	\$707

Ongoing, per month, one bird

ITEM	LOW	CONSIDERED
Pellets	\$5	\$12
Fresh vegetables and fruit, marginal cost above the household shop	\$5	\$12
Destructible toys, foraging materials, paper	\$6	\$15
Cuttlebone, mineral block, replacement perches	\$2	\$6
Monthly total	\$18	\$45
Annual wellness exam, spread over the year	\$4	\$10
Monthly, all in	\$22	\$55

A second budgie in the same cage adds roughly half again, not double.

FIRST YEAR, ROUGHLY \$470 TO \$1,200, AND THE FUND THAT IS NOT IN IT

Setup plus the bird plus the first exam plus eleven months of running costs. That is above what most starter guides quote, and the difference is the gram scale, the carrier, the sleep cage and a real vet line, which are the four items that change outcomes. Separately: diagnostics run \$50 to \$300 on top of an exam and emergency care runs \$100 to \$1,500 or more. Pet insurance is rarely available for a budgie, so put \$20 a month somewhere separate from the day the bird arrives.

Where not to save: the cage, because a small one gets replaced; the bar spacing, because it is a safety limit; the pellets, because the whole health section runs through the diet. Save on toys, which are paper and untreated wood, and on perches, which grow on unsprayed apple and willow.

First 30 days checklist

In order. Most of week one is doing less than you want to.

Before the bird arrives

- ☐ Cage built, sited and furnished, running for a few days
- ☐ Bar spacing measured, not assumed
- ☐ Avian vet found and the number written down
- ☐ Quarantine room ready if you already keep birds. Page 27
- ☐ Nonstick cookware audited, aerosols relocated
- ☐ Ask the seller what the bird is currently eating, and buy some of it

Days 1 to 7: leave it alone

- ☐ Food, water and cleaning only. No handling, no reaching in beyond the dishes
- ☐ Sit near the cage and talk. Let the bird watch the household happen
- ☐ Keep the same food it arrived on. Change one thing at a time, and not this week
- ☐ Check droppings every morning. A new bird's droppings are the first thing to go odd. Page 26
- ☐ Establish the sleep routine on day one: 10 to 12 hours of darkness, same time nightly
- ☐ Weigh at the end of the week if you can do it without a chase. Write the number down

Days 8 to 14

- ☐ Well-bird exam with the avian vet, whether or not anything looks wrong
- ☐ Hand resting inside the cage, doing nothing, in short sessions. Page 14
- ☐ Start offering vegetables daily, clipped to the bars. Expect refusal for a while
- ☐ Introduce a foraging feeder alongside the normal dish, not instead of it

Days 15 to 30

- ☐ Begin the pellet conversion if the bird came on seed. Weigh daily through it. Page 10
- ☐ Millet from the fingers, then the step-up cue once food is taken calmly
- ☐ Bird-proof one room properly and take the first flight session there. Page 8
- ☐ Weekly weighing established and logged on page 36
- ☐ Toy rotation started: swap two of the three to five in the cage
- ☐ End of quarantine, if applicable, and the introduction sequence begins

CHANGE ONE THING AT A TIME

A new cage, a new diet, a new room and a new person in the same fortnight gives you no way of telling which change caused the problem when one appears. Space them out. The bird is not in a hurry.

WHAT NORMAL LOOKS LIKE BY DAY 30

Eating and drinking visibly, droppings consistent, chattering, preening, sleeping on one foot with the head tucked, and grinding the beak quietly at bedtime, which is contentment. Pages 19 and 24 read those signals.

Symptom quick reference

What you see, what it might be, and how fast to move. A budgie that has visibly changed has been unwell for a while, so when in doubt, call.

WHAT YOU SEE	MOST LIKELY CAUSES	ACT
On the cage floor, fluffed	Serious illness of almost any kind; egg binding in a hen	Same day
Tail bobbing with each breath	Respiratory disease, an abdominal mass, obesity, toxin exposure	Same day
Open-mouth breathing or a click	Respiratory infection, goiter, inhaled irritant	Same day
Sudden collapse or seizure	PTFE or aerosol exposure, heavy metal, head trauma	Now. Fresh air first
Straining, wide stance, no droppings	Egg binding. Page 18	Now
Bleeding	Broken blood feather, cage injury, another bird	Firm, steady pressure; powder on the broken tip, never into the follicle. Vet at 2 to 3 minutes
Limping, dragging a foot, weak grip	Kidney or reproductive tumor pressing on the nerve; injury; leg band problem	Within days
Weight down 10% from baseline	Almost anything. Megabacteriosis is the classic quiet one	Within days
Eating well but still losing weight	Megabacteriosis, parasites, malabsorption. Page 23	Within days
Whole seed in the droppings	The gut is not processing food. Page 23	Within days
Green or yellow urates	Liver disease; psittacosis. Page 21	Within days
Watery droppings, solid part still formed	Polyuria: stress, watery food, kidney disease	24 hours, then call
Mushy or liquid fecal part	True diarrhea: infection, diet, toxin	Within days
Sneezing, wet cere, swollen eyes	Vitamin A deficiency, respiratory infection, irritant in the air	Within days
Crusty honeycombed cere or beak	Scaly face mites. Page 23	Within days
Cere turning brown in a cock	Reproductive tumor. Normal breeding condition in a hen	Within days
Overgrown beak or nails	Liver disease, mites, past injury. Not a grooming issue	Within days
Lump on chest or belly	Lipoma, xanthoma, hernia, tumor. Page 20	Within days
Feathers missing, head untouched	Plucking. Rule out medical causes first. Page 24	Within weeks
Feathers missing including the head	Not self-inflicted: a virus, or a cage mate. Page 22	Within days
Symmetrical feather loss with pins coming up	Normal molt. Page 25	Monitor
Regurgitating onto a toy or mirror	Hormonal, and normal in itself. Remove the object. Page 17	Monitor
Quiet bird that always chattered	Any illness. A change in a habit is a symptom	Within days

Daily, weekly & seasonal routine

Ten minutes a day, half an hour a week, and an hour a season.

Every day

- ☐ Change the water and wash the dish
- ☐ Fresh pellets; blow the husks off any seed dish before judging it full
- ☐ Vegetables in, and out again a few hours later
- ☐ Change the paper on the tray and read the droppings
- ☐ Look at the bird properly: posture, breathing, feathers, both feet gripping
- ☐ Supervised out-of-cage flight in a bird-proofed room
- ☐ Interaction: talking, training, or a session on the hand
- ☐ Cover or move to the sleep cage at a consistent hour

Every week

- ☐ Weigh, same time of day, and log it
- ☐ Rotate two toys out and two back in
- ☐ Scrub perches and dishes properly; replace anything frayed
- ☐ Wipe cage bars and the tray, and vacuum around the cage
- ☐ Offer a bath, two or three times a week
- ☐ Check feet, nails, cere, vent and under the leg band

Every month

- ☐ Full cage strip and clean, with the bird safely elsewhere
- ☐ Restock pellets and check the bag date; pellets lose vitamins with age. Review the weight log as a trend
- ☐ Re-audit the room against page 8. New candles and new cookware arrive quietly

Enrichment: tick what has been offered this month, and rotate what has not

- ☐ Food wrapped in plain paper
- ☐ Foraging feeder or puzzle
- ☐ Shredding: paper, cardboard, palm, yucca
- ☐ Soft untreated wood to chew
- ☐ Fresh branch with bark and leaves
- ☐ New perch position or height
- ☐ Bath or misting
- ☐ Training session: step up, target, recall
- ☐ Out-of-cage flight in a safe room
- ☐ Two toys rotated out and two in

Seasonal

WHEN	WHAT CHANGES
Spring and summer	Longer natural days push birds into breeding condition. Hold the artificial photoperiod steady rather than following the season, and watch hens for laying behavior. Page 17
Hot weather	A caged bird cannot leave the sun. Check for a moving sunbeam by mid-afternoon, bathe more often, and never leave a bird in a closed car
Fall	The heaviest molt in many birds. Feed well, bathe more, handle less. Page 25
Winter	Heating dries the air and is the season for space heaters, candles and scented products. Re-read page 8 in November. Keep the cage off cold exterior walls and away from radiators alike
Yearly	Wellness exam. Replace worn perches and the cover, and confirm the vet's after-hours arrangements

Power outages, travel & transport

For a bird, the danger in a blackout is usually what people light, not the cold.

A budgie does not depend on powered equipment the way a reptile or a fish does. There is no heater to fail and no filter to stall. What actually kills birds during an outage is the response: candles, kerosene and propane heaters, generators run too close to the house, a gas oven left open for warmth, and a fireplace lit in a room that has not been swept. Every one of those puts combustion products into the air of a small animal with an exceptionally efficient respiratory system.

DURING AN OUTAGE

No candles, no kerosene or propane heaters, no gas oven as a room heater. A generator runs outside and **at least 20 feet from any door, window or vent**, which is the CDC's figure; the CPSC rules out running one in or *near* an enclosed space, so an open garage door does not qualify. Keep a working carbon monoxide detector in the house. Use flashlights and battery lanterns. If the only available warmth is a combustion source, the bird goes to a friend's house or to a boarding facility instead, and that is not an overreaction.

Keeping a budgie warm without power

- Move the cage to the smallest interior room, away from windows and exterior doors.
- Cover the cage on three sides with blankets, leaving one side open for air. A covered cage holds the bird's own heat well.
- Keep feeding. A 30 g bird burns through its reserves in hours, and a bird that is cold needs more food, not less. This is the opposite of the advice for a reptile.
- Hot water bottles wrapped in towels, placed outside the cage, are safe. Chemical hand warmers are not: some release fumes, and none should be inside a cage a bird can chew.
- A healthy budgie tolerates a cool house better than most owners expect. Draft and damp are worse than temperature.

Travel and transport

SITUATION	WHAT TO DO
Vet trip	Small carrier, paper towel lining, no tall perch to fall off. Food and water at floor level. Cover it. Keep the car warm and the vents off the carrier
A long drive	The carrier is belted in and never in the trunk. Offer water at every stop. Do not open the carrier inside the car, ever
Moving house	The bird travels with you, not in the removal van. Set the cage up in a quiet room at the new house before anything else is unpacked, and expect a week of settling
Holidays	A budgie should not be left alone for more than 24 hours, even with full dishes. Water fouls, a dish tips, a bird gets stuck. Use the sitter sheet on page 35
Flying	Airline rules for live birds vary widely and change often, and some destinations require permits. Check with the airline directly, months ahead, and expect a health certificate to be required

NEVER LEAVE A BIRD IN A PARKED CAR

A car interior heats fast enough to kill a budgie in minutes, and it is the single commonest way a routine vet trip goes wrong. In cold weather the same car chills just as fast. The bird comes with you or it stays home.

Pet-sitter sheet

Fill it in and leave it on the fridge. Assume the sitter has never kept a bird.

Bird's name _____	Cock / hen _____
Owner _____	Phone _____
Avian vet _____	Phone _____
Emergency clinic _____	Phone _____
Backup contact _____	Phone _____
Normal weight (g) _____	Medications _____

Every day, please

- | | |
|---|--|
| ☐ Fresh water, dish washed, not just topped up | ☐ Paper on the tray changed. Glance at the droppings first |
| ☐ Pellets refilled. The husks on top of a seed dish are not food | ☐ Cover the cage at the usual hour for 10 to 12 hours of darkness |
| ☐ Fresh vegetables in the morning, removed a few hours later | ☐ Talk to the bird. Ten minutes near the cage counts |

PLEASE NEVER, WHILE WE ARE AWAY

Cook with nonstick pans in this house, or run the self-cleaning oven. Fumes from an overheated nonstick surface kill birds and there is no warning.

Use aerosols, air fresheners, plug-ins, scented candles or incense anywhere in the house.

Let the bird out of the cage. Even a tame budgie is a lost budgie if a door opens.

Let another animal into the room.

Give any food from the never list below.

Never feed

Avocado, onion, garlic, chocolate, caffeine, alcohol, anything salty, and anything cooked with butter or oil.

Call us, or the vet, if you see

- | | |
|--|--|
| • The bird on the floor of the cage, fluffed up | • Blood anywhere |
| • Its tail bobbing with each breath, or an open beak | • Food untouched for a day |
| • No droppings on the paper, or far fewer than usual | • Anything that just seems different from the day before |

Where the pellets are _____

Where the paper and cleaning things are _____

Anything else _____

Weigh weekly, at the same time of day, before the first feed. Write the number even when it is boring, because the boring numbers are what make one interesting number readable. Act on a drop of more than about 10% from the bird's own baseline, or any steady decline across three weighings. Take this page to the vet.

Equipment & vet log

What was replaced, what was treated, and what is due next.

Equipment & consumables

ITEM	REPLACED	NEXT DUE	NOTES
Perches			
Cuttlebone / mineral block			
Pellet bag opened			
Cage cover			

Veterinary

DATE	REASON	WEIGHT (G)	FINDINGS, TREATMENT, FOLLOW-UP

Twelve-month planner

MONTH	WEIGHED	WELLNESS EXAM	CAGE DEEP CLEAN	NOTES
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	
	☐	☐	☐	

Glossary

Terms used earlier in this book, in the sense they were used.

Blood feather	A feather still growing, with a blood supply running into the shaft. Breaking one bleeds seriously in a bird this small
Cere	The fleshy patch above the beak holding the nostrils. Blue in adult cocks, tan or brown in hens, pink or pale in juveniles
Chlamydia psittaci	The bacterium that causes psittacosis, or parrot fever. Infects people as well as birds
Crop	A storage pouch at the base of the neck where food waits before digestion. A crop that stops emptying is a serious sign
Dystrophic feather	A feather that has grown abnormally: bent, clubbed, pinched at the base, or failing to emerge
French moult	The chronic feather form of avian polyomavirus in budgerigars, leaving a fledgling unable to fly
Goiter	An enlarged thyroid, from iodine deficiency. Presents as a breathing noise rather than a visible swelling
Hepatic lipidosis	Fatty liver disease. Fat accumulating in the liver, most often from a seed diet
Keel	The ridge of breastbone down the center of the chest, used to score body condition by feel
Knemidocoptes pilae	The mite that causes scaly face and scaly leg in budgies
Lipoma	A benign fatty tumor, usually on the chest or belly, associated with high-fat diets
Macrorhabdus ornithogaster	Avian gastric yeast, once called megabacteria. The classic cause of a budgie eating well and losing weight
Molt	The ordinary, gradual replacement of feathers. Symmetrical, with pin feathers rising before old ones drop
Monomorphic	A species whose sexes look alike. Budgies are not: the cere sexes them, which is unusual among parrots
Pin feather	A new feather still in its waxy sheath. Tender, and preened out by the bird or its partner
Polyuria	Too much liquid urine, with the solid fecal part still formed. Different from diarrhea, and often confused with it
Photoperiod	Hours of light per day. The main lever on hormonal behavior and egg laying
PBFD	Psittacine beak and feather disease, a circovirus causing progressive feather and beak damage
PTFE	Polytetrafluoroethylene, the nonstick coating. Releases a gas lethal to birds at around 280°C (536°F)
Psittacine	Of the parrot family. Budgies are small psittacines, not finches
Quarantine	Isolating a new bird in a separate room, on separate equipment, for 30 to 45 days
Salpingohysterectomy	Surgical removal of a hen's reproductive tract. The definitive answer to repeated egg binding
Stridor	A harsh breathing noise caused by narrowed airway. In budgies, classically goiter
Urates	The chalky white part of a dropping: uric acid, how a bird excretes nitrogen while conserving water
Xanthoma	A yellow, thickened, cholesterol-laden patch of skin. Another sign of a high-fat diet

Sources, version history & about

Where the numbers in this book came from.

Veterinary and public health sources

SOURCE	WHAT IT SUPPLIED
LafeberVet, <i>Basic Information Sheet: Parakeet</i>	Weight, life span, incubation and clutch, heart and respiratory rates, body temperature, minimum cage dimension and bar spacing, household temperature
MSD / Merck Veterinary Manual, <i>Overview of Pet Birds</i>	The cage size and bar spacing table for budgerigars
MSD / Merck, <i>Management and Nutritional Diseases of Pet Birds</i>	Wing clipping method and cage placement; goiter and the Lugol's iodine figure, hypovitaminosis A, the obesity definition and keel score, calcium deficiency
MSD / Merck, <i>Reproductive Diseases of Pet Birds</i>	Chronic laying management and the 8-hour photoperiod, leuprolide and deslorelin, egg binding signs and treatment
MSD / Merck, <i>Parasitic and Viral Diseases of Pet Birds</i>	<i>Knemidocoptes</i> appearance with ivermectin and moxidectin dosing; avian polyomavirus, French moult, the vaccine schedule, PBFD signs and PCR diagnosis
MSD / Merck, <i>Bacterial, Mycotic and Toxicoses of Pet Birds</i>	Chlamydiosis and the 45-day doxycycline course; <i>Macrorhabdus ornithogaster</i> and the amphotericin B protocol; PTFE at 280°C (536°F) and the lead and zinc source lists
VCA Animal Hospitals, <i>Feeding Budgies</i>	The 60 to 80% pellet and 20 to 25% fresh split, four conversion methods, millet and grit guidance, the supplement note
VCA, <i>Fruits and Vegetables in Bird Diets and Birds: Abnormal Droppings</i>	The vitamin A produce list, iceberg lettuce and celery, avocado, onion and garlic, washing; the three dropping components, polyuria against diarrhea, and the 24-hour rule
NASPHV and CDC, <i>Compendium of Measures to Control Chlamydia psittaci Infection Among Humans and Pet Birds</i>	The 30-day quarantine floor with testing, that routine prophylactic antibiotic treatment is discouraged, the 45-day doxycycline course with the 30-day budgerigar exception, cleaning precautions, and the human illness picture
Lafeber (Stephanie Lamb, DVM; Susan Orosz, DVM); LafeberVet, <i>Avian Emergency and Critical Care</i>	The 12-hour limit without food for a budgerigar and the 10% weight-loss threshold; daily weighing before the first feed; the 80 to 90°F supplemental-heat range and the signs of overheating
VCA, <i>Wing Clipping, Blood or Pin Feathers, Egg Binding, Polyoma Virus Infection, Nursing Care for Sick Pet Birds, Respiratory Disease in Birds</i>	Blood-feather first aid and why a feather is not pulled at home; the 48-hour egg marker, the vent bulge and prolapse; polyomavirus mortality under 15 days and carrier shedding; the 75 to 80°F recovery range; tail bobbing as respiratory effort
Merck, <i>Viral Diseases</i> ; Chicago Exotics Animal Hospital, <i>Polyoma Virus</i>	The 90-day quarantine for an aviary and shedding for up to 90 days; vertical transmission parent to embryo, documented in budgerigars alone
UC Davis Clinical Animal Behavior Service; Lafeber, <i>Pet Bird and Parrot Behavior</i> ; US CDC and CPSC	The 10 to 12 hour sleep figure and that covering a cage may not give optimal rest; the body-language cues on pages 19 and 24; the 20-foot generator distance and carbon monoxide guidance
Peer-reviewed case series on <i>Macrorhabdus</i> in cockatiels, budgerigars and grey parrots	That the infection was found more often in the cockatiels examined than the budgerigars, and the 12 to 24 hour acute form on page 23
Veterinary literature on avian renal disease	Renal tumors as notably common in budgerigars, with lameness as the usual presenting sign

Beastly Facts guides drawn on: budgie cage setup, health issues, handling, enrichment, cost, and the cere color guide, plus the cross-species bird guides written since version 2.0, which now carry pages this package used to source externally: household hazards, photoperiod and sleep, pellet conversion, quarantine, droppings, wing clipping, sexing and body condition, feather loss and molt, chronic egg laying, emergency and travel, body language, avian polyomavirus, avian gastric yeast, colony and aviary keeping, and choosing a pet bird. Where they disagreed with a veterinary source, the veterinary source is what is printed here.

Where the sources disagree

Five figures where credible references do not match, and what this book prints instead.

FIGURE	THE DISAGREEMENT, AND THE CHOICE
Millet spray	The site's bird data gives a small piece 2 to 3 times a week. VCA's budgie feeding page gives small quantities once or twice a month , and does not recommend honey sticks at all. This book prints the VCA figure, because it is roughly a tenfold difference on the fattiest thing in the cage, in the species whose commonest killer is fatty liver disease
Pellet share	Some care references give 60 to 70% pellets. VCA gives 60 to 80% with 20 to 25% fresh, and page 10 prints that
Captive life span	Published figures run from 4 to 6 years to 15. LafeberVet's parakeet sheet gives a mean of 7 to 15 years , which is what pages 4 and 20 print, with the note that the low end is almost always diet
Cage minimum	18×18×18 in, 18×18×24 in and 20×20×30 in all appear in credible sources. Neither end was picked: page 5 prints 18×18 in as the floor and 20×20×30 in as the target, and bar spacing as a 3/8 to 1/2 in range, for the same reason
Doxycycline course	Forty-five days is the figure usually quoted. The NASPHV and CDC compendium makes a budgerigar-specific exception at 30 days , and puts 21 to 30 days within reach for psittacines generally. Page 21 prints both

Version history

VERSION	DATE	TEMPLATE	WHAT CHANGED
1.0	Aug 2026	pre-t3	First edition, 20 pages on the earlier layout
2.1	Sep 2026	t3	Corrections pass, cross-checked page by page against the site's new cross-species bird articles. The 24-hour no-eating line on page 10 was corrected to Lafeber's 12 hours for a budgerigar; page 27 lost the prophylactic-antibiotic option, which the public-health compendium discourages; page 21 gained the 30-day budgerigar doxycycline exception; page 23's avian gastric yeast entry was rebalanced across species and gained the 12 to 24 hour acute form; blood-feather first aid was corrected to firm pressure with no pulling at home; weighing moved from weekly to daily; and the body-language cues owners most often read backwards were added to pages 19 and 24, which moved beak grinding off page 31. The back matter split into two reference pages, 39 and 40, taking the guide from 39 pages to 40.
2.0	Sep 2026	t3	Full rebuild on the current template. New pages for hazards, light and sleep, the flock decision, clipping, sexing and weight, chronic laying, egg binding, quarantine, droppings, molt and plucking, plus four health pages. Diet rewritten around the veterinary pellet split

Beastly Facts publishes fact-checked care references for keepers who would rather read one accurate thing than ten contradictory ones. This is a husbandry reference, not veterinary advice.

Budgie Care Package · Version 2.1 · Template t3 · September 2026 · 40 pages · For personal use by the purchaser. Please don't redistribute.